

'STOP' USING THE FUTURE TENSE

Today's lesson is all about looking towards the future as we explore the concept of 'future tenses,' but you'll soon discover why that term isn't entirely accurate. This lesson is chock-full of examples and includes a quiz to test your understanding. Ready to challenge the grammar perfectionists and enhance your future expressions in English?

Is there actually a future tense?

You might be surprised to know that saying “**the future tense**” is incorrect.

Why?



Because there is no such thing as the future tense in English—**mind blown!**

If you look in most grammar books, you'll see a section named something like “*Talking about the future*”, not “*Future tenses*”. In fact, there are only two tenses in English: **the present** and **the past**. These tenses are further divided into aspects like **continuous** and **perfect**.

We tend to call each **tense + aspect** “**a tense**”, for example, the **present perfect tense** or the **past continuous tense**. It's just simpler to think about them like this, and it's probably what you've been taught at school and all through your English-learning journey.

Back to the future! A key feature in English tenses is verb inflection. In the present tense, for instance, we add **-s** to third-person singular verbs, and in the past tense, regular verbs often get an **-ed** suffix.

like → likes → liked



However, the future differs from the present and past tenses in a significant way: we don't have a specific verb inflection to indicate it. So, **there is no future tense**—technically.

But I think it's so much easier to think about the future as a tense in the same way as you think of the present and past tenses. So, I am taking a stand: **this lesson is about future tenses**. And I'm going to explain how you can use the future tenses in English.

Let's start with **will**. This is the word that people associate most strongly with the future. **Will** is a modal verb that can be used to talk about the future. We use it in what we call the **future simple, future continuous, future perfect simple** and **future perfect continuous**. Let's take a look at how these future tenses are used.

Future Simple

will + base verb

We use the future simple to-

- **make predictions.**
- **talk about decisions made at the moment of speaking.**
- **make offers and promises.**
 - *It **will be** a wonderful party, I just know it!*
 - *The dog's getting a bit boisterous. **I'll walk** him.*
 - ***I'll get** you another size to try on.*

Future Continuous

will + be + -ing verb



We use the future continuous to **talk about temporary actions and events that will be in progress at a time later than now.**

- *This time tomorrow, we'll **be sitting** down to dinner at my dream restaurant.*
- *I'll **be walking** to work tomorrow as my car is at the mechanic's.*

Future Perfect Simple

will + have + past participle

We use the future perfect simple to **talk about events that will be finished at a certain time later than now.** It's like we walk into the future and then turn around and look back.

- *We **will** definitely **have arrived** by 7pm.*
- *They'll **have** already **eaten** before they come round, so we don't need to feed them.*

Future Perfect Continuous

will + have been + -ing verb

We use the future perfect continuous **to emphasise the duration of an event that will be happening at a time later than now.** It's similar to the future perfect simple in that we look back from a time in the future.

- *In six months' time, we **will have been working** here for seven years.*
- *By this time next week, I **will have been travelling** for four months.*

A quick note about the future perfect simple and continuous here. With some verbs, you can use either tense **with no change in meaning.** One of those verbs is **work.**



- *In six months' time, we **will have worked / been working** here for seven years.*

They mean exactly the same thing. In the future perfect continuous, there is more of a feeling of emphasis on just how long you've worked there, but really you can use either.

Other verbs like this include **live**, **play** and **teach**. However, with lots of verbs, like **read**, you can't use them interchangeably.

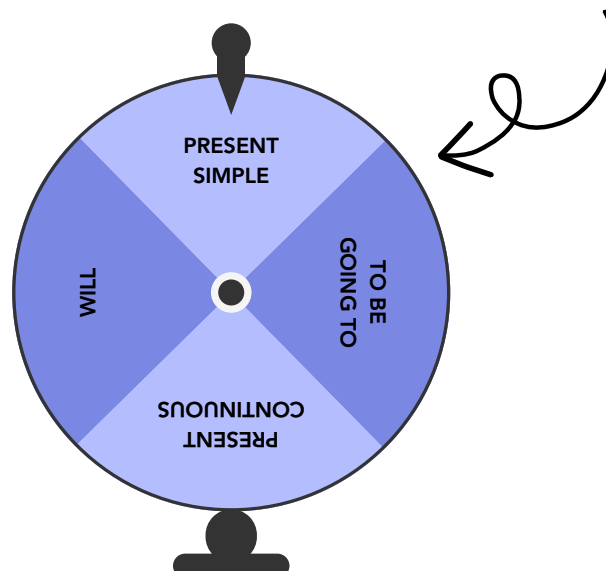
- *By tomorrow night, I **will have been reading** this book for two months.*

This means you won't have finished the book, and you cannot simply replace **will have been reading** with **will have read**. If you did, the sentence would not be grammatically correct because '**will have read**' means you will be finished reading.

Those are your four future tenses. Come at me, Grammar Police.

Talk About The Future In Other Ways

There are, of course, other ways to talk about the future apart from **will**. And we're going to look at them now using my **Wheel of Fortune!** (Or my future tenses wheel.)



As you can see, we have **will**, which I've already talked about. We can also see **to be going to**.

To Be Going To

be going to + base verb

We use **to be going to** in two main ways:

- to make predictions based on present evidence
 - *John is so drunk! He's **going to have** a terrible hangover tomorrow.*
- to talk about plans and intentions
 - *I'm **going to spend** the day at home tomorrow, just chilling.*

When the verb in the infinitive is **go**, we often shorten the sentence:

- *I'm **going** [to go] **shopping** later.*

Present Continuous

We use the present continuous to **talk about plans and arrangements**. Yes, plans again. There is often little difference between the present continuous and to be going to when we're talking about plans. However, when **we use the present continuous we have made a firm decision to do something**.

What do I mean by a '**firm decision**'? It usually means I know exactly what I'm doing, where, when and with whom. Often, but not always, we have arranged to do something. Look at these examples:

- *I **am having** lunch with my friend Claire tomorrow. (arrangement)*
- *We're **spending** the summer on a yacht in Croatia. (probably booked, but if not, very definitely happening)*

You could say—

- *We're **going to spend** the summer on a yacht in Croatia.*

This is a plan, but it's unlikely that you've booked it, and it just feels less certain than when we use the **present continuous**.

We **don't use the present continuous** to make predictions when an event is outside of our control.

- *The sky is so dark. It's ~~raining~~ **going to rain** in a few minutes.*

And we don't use it to talk about permanent situations in the future.

- *We are ~~living~~ **going to live** in the countryside for the rest of our lives.*

Present Simple

And finally, I want to talk about the present simple, another tense that, rather confusingly, we use to talk about the future. We use the present simple to **talk about timetabled or scheduled events**.

- *Our plane **leaves** at 2:10 tomorrow morning.*
- *The exam **finishes** at 7, so pick me up then.*

Choose the correct answer for each question.

- 1) The conference _____ tomorrow at 5pm.
 - a. begins
 - b. is beginning
 - c. will begin
 - 2) "Our flight departs at 9am," is an example of which tense?
 - a. Present simple
 - b. Future simple
 - c. Present continuous
 - 3) What is the structure for 'be going to'?
 - a. be going to + base verb
 - b. be going to + past participle
 - c. be going to + -ing verb
 - 4) By this time next year, I _____ my degree.
 - a. will get
 - b. will have got
 - c. am going to get
 - 5) This time tomorrow, we _____ to New York.
 - a. will fly
 - b. will be flying
 - c. will have been flying
 - 6) _____ your grandparents this weekend?
 - a. Do you visit
 - b. Will you have visited
 - c. Are you going to visit
 - 7) How many tenses are there in the English language according to traditional grammar?
 - a. three
 - b. two
 - c. four
 - 8) What do we often use the future simple tense for?
 - a. to make predictions
 - b. to discuss plans
 - c. to emphasise duration
 - 9) "It will rain tomorrow," is -
 - a. a prediction
 - b. an offer
 - c. a plan
 - 10) I _____ to the pub later today.
 - a. go
 - b. will have gone
 - c. am going to go

The End!